capital: the minting of coins there in his "second reign" – that is, the years after his release from Saljuq captivity in AH 548/1153 CE until his death in AH 556/1161 CE – strongly indicates that the sultan again besieged and even occupied Ghazna toward the end of his rule. This may hint that his earlier victory against Bahram Shah in AH 544/1150 CE had also been intended as a conquest intended to integrate Ghazna within Shansabani territories, rather than an act of avenging destruction. All in all, even though 'Ala' al-Din's violent revenge earned him long-term infamy and the epithet *Jahan-suz* or "World Incendiary," Juzjani likely described the actual destruction at the sites with not a little hyperbole.[71]

Meanwhile, Bahram Shah eventually returned from India, and he and his sons presided at Ghazna for another decade. But 'Ala' al-Din Husain's rampage had been both a symptom and an exacerbation of their decline: the Ghaznavids' hold over their own capital could not withstand the violent Oghüz takeover in AH 557/1162 CE[72] – after 'Ala' al-Din had *again* briefly occupied the capital the year before (cf. above). The reign of the last Ghaznavid sultan Khusrau Shah (r. AH 452–479/1160–1186 CE) passed almost entirely in the Panjab. Thereafter, the Shansabanis effectively inherited both the Ghaznavids' opportunities and challenges, entering some erstwhile Ghaznavid territories with little effort, while also provoking and confronting the Saljuqs with mixed results (see Chapter 5).

'Ala' al-Din Husain's wildly unpredictable reign – marked by successes, failures, and dramatic recoveries – was of a piece with the unforeseen events that elevated him to the Firuzkuh throne in the first place. Although the untimely death of his older brother Sultan Baha' al-Din had benefited 'Ala' al-Din, his position was unsafe due to the existence of claimants to the Firuzkuh throne: Baha' al-Din's two young sons, Shams al-Din and Shihab al-Din. Although 'Ala' al-Din had the boys imprisoned in the fort of Wajiristan, fate restored their rightful prerogatives: upon 'Ala' al-Din's death, his son and successor Saif al-Din (r. AH 556–558/1161–1163 CE) ordered the release of his cousins from their ten-year imprisonment, but the latter's own unexpected death in AH 558/1163 CE meant that the older Shams al-Din was crowned Ghiyath al-Din, Sultan of Firuzkuh. Precisely what 'Ala' al-Din had tried to prevent had nonetheless come to pass.

Sultan Ghiyath al-Din's younger brother Shihab al-Din eventually went on to great successes of his own, including the establishment of a third Shansabani lineage (cf. map, p. xv; Genealogy, p. xvii; Chapters 4 and 5). Having captured Ghazna in AH 569/1173–1174 CE by means of a joint effort with his older brother Sultan Ghiyath al-Din, Shihab al-Din was eventually crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din,[73] and shortly thereafter went on to consolidate the ex-Ghaznavid holdings throughout Zamindawar. The younger Shansabani also "extracted Multan from the hands of the Qaramatis [Shi'a-affiliated Isma'ilis]" in AH 571/1175–1176 CE. This was a momentous period for the Firuzkuh Shansabanis as well.